

Session 8: The Structure of the Eden Narrative

Key Takeaways

- The Eden narrative is designed in seven distinct scenes that have been ordered in chiastic symmetry. The structure invites us to ponder how the events before and after the pivot in the story contribute to the main message of the literary unit.
- There are two common interpretations of how the creation account in Genesis 1:1-2:3 relates to what seems like a secondary account in the Eden story (Gen. 2:4-3:24). View one holds that Genesis 2:4-25 elaborates day six of Genesis 1:1-2:3. View two states that Genesis 2:4-25 follows as a sequel from Genesis 1:1-2:3.

Macro Design of the Eden Narrative

The garden of Eden story is found in Genesis 2:4-3:24. Key Hebrew scholars Jerome Walsh and David Dorsey are in agreement that the passage is designed with seven distinct scenes that have been ordered in a chiastic symmetry. This unique design invites the reader to contrast each scene with its corresponding partner. We'll be studying the narrative along the contours of this design.

2:4-17	Humanity Is Created and Placed in the Garden Characters: Yahweh, the human Setting: From outside the garden to inside the garden		
	2:18-25	Man and Woman Created and Unified Characters: Yahweh, the human, animals, woman Setting: inside the garden	
		3:1-5	Dialogue Between the Snake and the Woman Characters: snake, woman Setting: inside the garden
		3:6-7	The Woman and Man Eat from the Forbidden Tree Characters: snake, woman, man Setting: the center of the garden A and the woman saw that the tree was good for
Adapted from Jerome Walsh, <i>Style and Structure in Biblical Hebrew Narrative</i> , 21-23, and David Dorsey, <i>Literary Structure of the Old Testament</i> , 49-50. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).			

			eating B and desirable to the eyes and desirable for becoming wise C and <i>she took</i> from its fruit and <i>she ate</i> C' and <i>she gave</i> also to her husband and <i>he ate</i> B' and the eyes of the two of them were opened and they knew they were naked A' and the leaves of a fig tree and made garments
	3:8-13	Dialogue Between God and the Humans Characters: Yahweh, man, woman Setting: inside the garden	
	3:14-21	Consequences For the Snake, Man and Woman Divided Characters: Yahweh, the man, woman, snake Setting: inside the garden	
3:22-24	Humanity is Banished from the Garden Characters: Yahweh (active), the human (passive) Setting: Inside the garden, moves to the land outside the garden		
Adapted from Jerome Walsh, <i>Style and Structure in Biblical Hebrew Narrative</i> , 21-23, and David Dorsey, <i>Literary Structure of the Old Testament</i> , 49-50. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).			

Translation Comparisons of Generations

The first scene of the Eden narrative starts with what sounds like a heading, “these are the generations of the skies and land” (Gen. 2:4a). This verse is typically translated a couple different ways.

- NIV: “This is the **account** of the heavens and the earth when they were created, when the Lord God made the earth and the heavens.”
- NASB: “These are the **generations** of the heavens and the earth when they were created, in the day that the Lord God made the earth and the heavens.”
- NRSV: “Thi*s* is the **account** of the heavens and the earth when they were created, in the day that the Lord God made earth and heaven.”
- NLT: “This is the **account** of the creation of the heavens and the earth. When the Lord God made the earth and the heavens.”
- KJV: “These are the **generations** of the heavens and of the earth when they were created, in the day that the Lord God made the earth and the heavens.”

The word “generations” in Hebrew is *toledot* (תולדות), from the root *yalad* (ילד), meaning “to give birth.” It is used to refer to what issued and generated from the key character named in the formula. The occurrence of this word at the start of the Eden story raises a curious interpretive question. How does the narrative that

follows—the creation of the human and the garden—relate to the literary unit we just finished reading about creation?

The Relationship Between Genesis 1:1-2:3 and 2:4-3:24

Genesis 1:2:3 paints a large-scale picture of God’s establishment of cosmic order. This order allows the world to become a sacred space for God’s presence to dwell with his divine images who represent his rule. With no end to the seventh-day rest, it’s as if this creation account is giving us the ideal cosmic setup. So why does the Eden narrative fail to acknowledge the garden and the humans who were already created in Genesis 1?

The Not-Yet-Existent Plants of Genesis 2:5

Genesis 2:5 paints a portrait of unproductive dry land that is devoid of plant life (cf. day three of creation account in Gen. 1) and human life (cf. day six of creation account in Gen. 1). This line returns us to a state of *tohu-vavohu* from Genesis 1:2, but here the focus is on the dry land. What is the difference between “shrub of the field” (שיח השדה) and “plant of the field” (עשב השדה)?

- **Shrub (שיח):** non-edible shrubs, used mostly on uncultivated land and wilderness areas (see Gen. 21:15). In Job 30:4, 7, the scene involves starving people in desolate areas, eating plants that are hardly edible in order to survive. The shock of the scene is of people trying to eat and live off of “shrub.”
- **Plant (עשב):** edible plants and vegetables. In Genesis 1:11, it is the growth from the dry land after it emerges from the sea. In Genesis 1:29-30, these are the plants given to humans and animals as food (see also Gen. 9:3; Exod. 10:15).

The dual plant reference is a way of talking about any and all plant growth, inedible or edible—none of it was growing in the land because of lack of water. Two reasons are given for the absence of any kind of plants.

1. No rain (preview of the flood narrative)
2. No human to work the ground (preview of the human’s purpose in Eden in 2:15, and after the exile from Eden in 3:23).

The Hinge Function of Genesis 2:4

Genesis 2:4 functions as a hinge between the two large literary blocks of Genesis 1:1-2:3 and Genesis 2:4-3:24.

Reference	Text
Genesis 2:4a	These are the generations
<i>The Hinge Function of Genesis 2:4.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).	

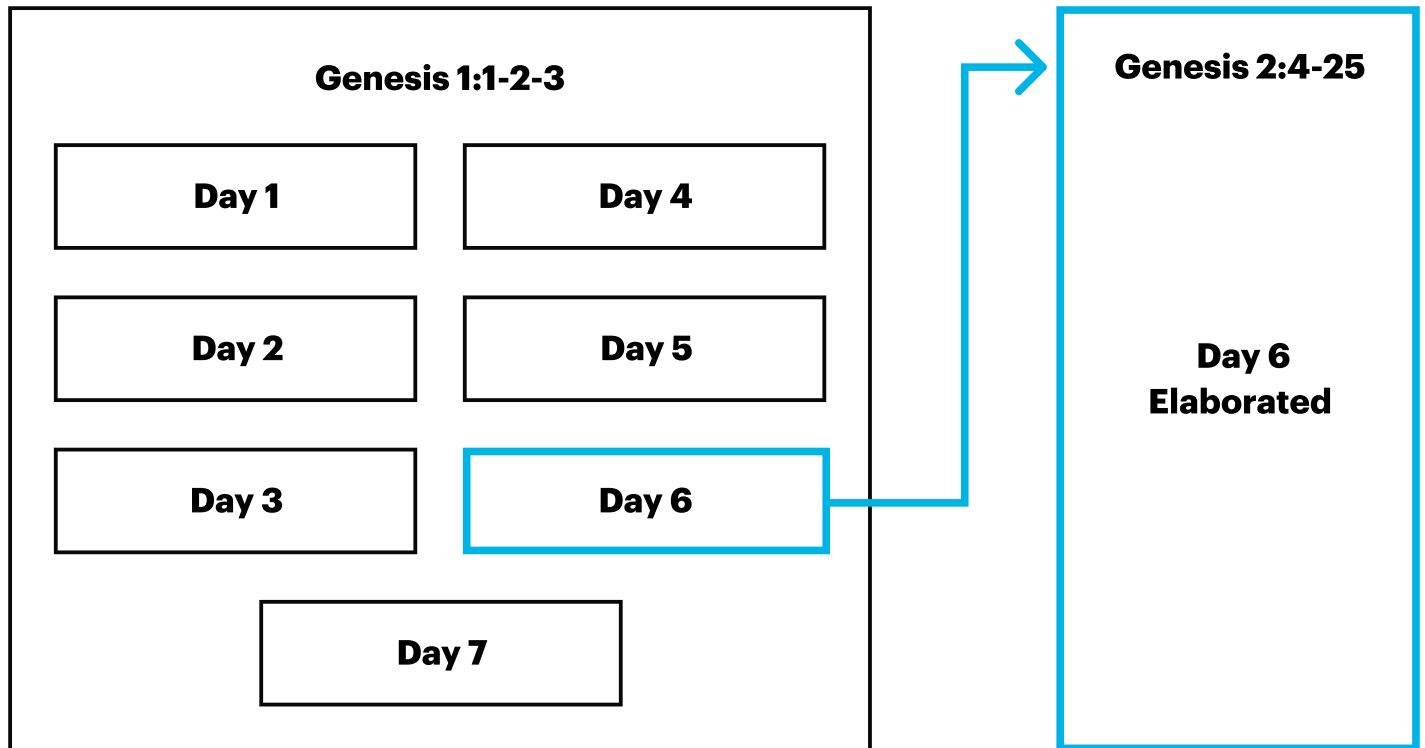
Reference	Text		
	A	of the skies and the land	
		B	when they were created :
Genesis 2:4b		B'	in the day Yahweh Elohim made
	A'	the land and skies ...	
The Hinge Function of Genesis 2:4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).			

On its own, this line seems like a parallel design of two paired statements. However, when 2:4b is joined to the following verses, it becomes clear that the phrase “in the day Yahweh *Elohim* made the land and the skies” is a subordinate temporal clause that introduces all of 2:4b-6. This sets up the main clause that begins the narrative action in 2:7 with the creation of the human.

The point of Genesis 2:4a is to situate the following narrative of Genesis 2:4b-3:24 as taking place after the creation of the skies and land recounted in Genesis 1:1-2:3. The point of Genesis 2:4b is to link backward so that Genesis 1:1-2:3 becomes a prologue to the following narrative.

View 1: Genesis 2:4-25 Elaborates Day Six of Genesis 1:1-2:3

Many interpreters throughout history have read the Eden narrative (Gen. 2:4-25) as a recursive elaboration of day six in Genesis 1, where animals and humans are created on the land. In this view, the narrative technique of the author is to first present an overview narrative (Gen. 1:1-2:3), and then double back and provide a more in-depth presentation of a key moment in the previous narrative (Gen. 2:4-25).



Genesis 2:4-25 Elaborates Day Six. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Challenges with View 1

- If Genesis 2 is a recapitulation of day six of Genesis 1, then the statement in Genesis 2:5-6 makes little sense: "...and no plant of the field was yet in the land, nor had any vegetation of the field yet sprouted." In Genesis 1, God generates plants from the ground on day three, not day six.
- In Genesis 1, the animals are created first, then humans. In Genesis 2, the human is created first, then the animals.
- If Genesis 2 is re-presenting day six, it is hard to imagine that the author wants us to think of all the events of Genesis 2:4-25 as taking place in one day.
- The heading used in Genesis 2:4a "these are the generations of ..." occurs 10 times in Genesis in a similar way (it also occurs three times outside of Genesis).

Usage of Toledot in Genesis

The transitional heading "these are the generations of" is used in two primary ways in Genesis.

1. **A sequel:** To introduce a new literary unit by naming a key person who, along with their children, will be the focus in the following literary unit.
2. **A recursive/sequel:** To introduce the non-chosen son's family line through history (Cain in [4:17-22](#); Japeth and Ham in [10:1](#); Ishmael in [25:12](#); Esau in [36:1](#), [9](#)), and then double back and focus on the chosen son, Seth, Shem, Isaac, Jacob's sons ([5:1](#); [11:10](#); [25:19](#); [37:2](#)).

Reference	Verse	Narrative Role	Relation to Previous Literary Unit
Gen 2:4a	"These are the generations of the heavens and the earth when they were created, in the day that the Lord God made the earth and the heavens."	To be determined ...	To be determined ...
Gen 5:1	"This is the scroll of the generations of humanity. When God created human, he made him in the likeness of God."	Transition from Cain's line to Seth's line	Recursive/Sequel
Gen 6:9	"These are the generations of Noah."	Transition from pre-flood rebellion to Noah's story	Sequel
Gen 10:1	"Now these are the generations of Shem, Ham, and Japheth, the sons of Noah; and sons were born to them after the flood."	Transition from Noah and 3 sons to the descendants of Noah's 3 sons	Sequel
Gen 11:10	"These are the generations of Shem."	Transition from descendants of Noah's 3 sons to Shem's line	Recursive/Sequel
Gen 11:27	"Now these are the generations of Terah."	Transition from Shem's line to Terah's line and to Abraham	Sequel
Gen 25:12	"Now these are the generations of Ishmael, Abraham's son, whom Hagar the Egyptian, Sarah's maid, bore to Abraham;"	Transition from Abraham to Ishmael's line	Sequel
Gen 25:19	"Now these are the generations of Isaac, Abraham's son:"	Transition from Abraham to Isaac's line	Sequel
Gen 36:1	"Now these are the generations of Esau (that is, Edom)."	Transition from Jacob to Esau's family line	Sequel

Usage of Toledot in Genesis. Walton, John H. (2015). *The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2-3 and the Human Origins Debate*. IVP Academic: An Imprint of InterVarsity Press. By BibleProject for Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Reference	Verse	Narrative Role	Relation to Previous Literary Unit
Gen 36:9	"These then are the generations of Esau the father of Edom in the hill country of Seir."		
Gen 37:2	"These are the generations of Jacob."	Transition from Jacob to Jacob's family	Recursive/Sequel
<i>Usage of Toledot in Genesis.</i> Walton, John H. (2015). <i>The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2-3 and the Human Origins Debate</i> . IVP Academic: An Imprint of InterVarsity Press. By BibleProject for Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).			

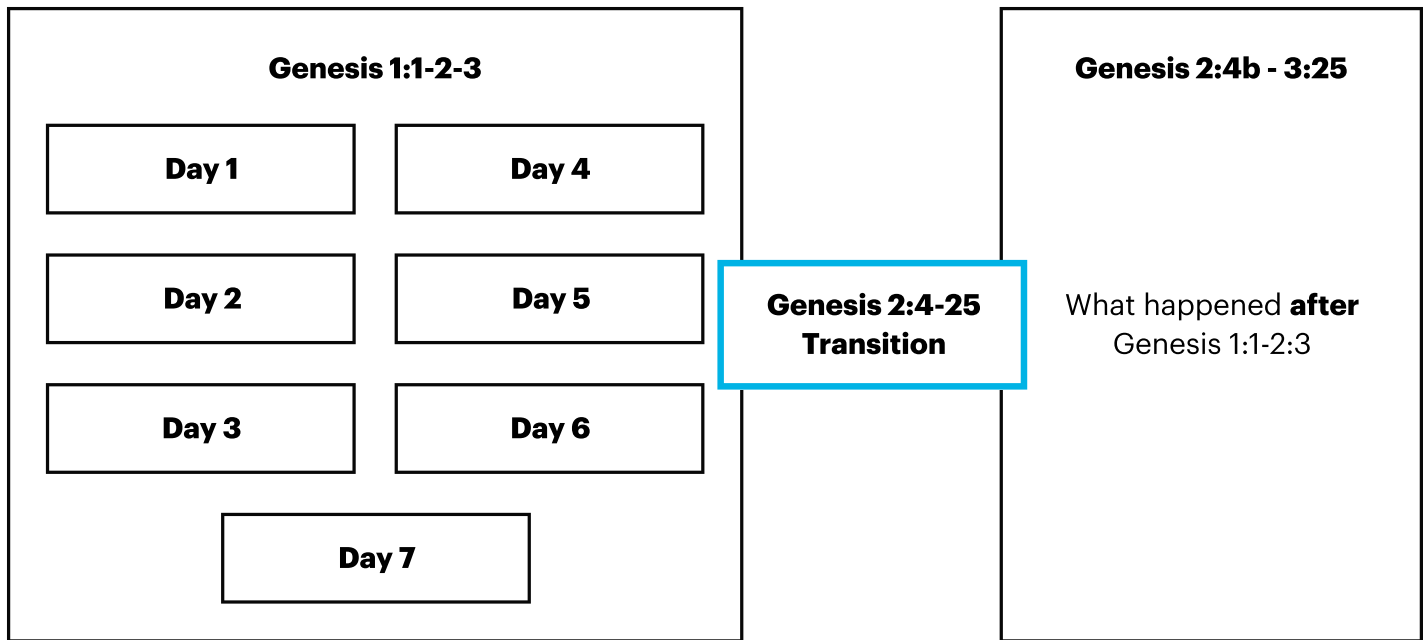
As we study this repeated phrase, we can see even in the recursive/sequel occurrence that the point of the overlapping text is not to elaborate or give a more detailed account. Rather, it aims to profile the non-chosen son's line far forward in narrative time so that the narrative can come back and focus on the chosen son's lineage. John Walton summarizes his key takeaway.

"There is therefore no precedent by which to conclude that the introductory formula in Genesis 2:4 is bringing the reader back into the middle of the previous account to give a more detailed description of a part of the story that was previously told. Such introductions never do this in the rest of Genesis ... Furthermore, Genesis 2 does not follow the pattern of the recursive examples that follow a genealogy of the unfavored line before returning to the story of the favored line. This evidence then leads us to give strong preference to the view that Genesis 2 is not adding further detail to what happened during the sixth day in Genesis 1."

Walton, John H. (2015). [*The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2-3 and the Human Origins Debate*](#). IVP Academic: An Imprint of InterVarsity Press.

View 2: Genesis 2:4-25 Follows as a Sequel From Genesis 1:1-2:3

View 2 holds that the Eden narrative is the chronological sequel to the Genesis 1 creation account. The implications of this conclusion are extremely significant for the interpretation of [Genesis 2:4-4:26](#), the Adam and Eve and the Cain and Abel stories.



Genesis 2 As a Sequel to Genesis 1. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

1. It means that Genesis 2:4b-25 is not another cosmic creation story that parallels Genesis 1. Rather, the narrative focuses on one particular spot of the already created dry land and shows God preparing it as a special Heaven-on-Earth place. Genesis 1 begins with a disordered cosmos, while Genesis 2 begins with a disordered land. Genesis 1 portrays the entire cosmos as a sacred space, and Genesis 2 portrays one particular place within the cosmos as God's special dwelling place.
2. It means that Genesis 2-3 is focused not on the creation of the cosmos but on the story of how God's ideal for creation in Genesis 1 was ruined and distorted into the reality that the reader inhabits.
3. It means that Genesis 1:26-28 describes the creation and vocational role of humanity as a whole. This opens the interpretive possibility that Genesis 1 describes the creation of general humanity in the narrative past, distinct from the narrative of Adam and Eve's creation in Genesis 2:4-25. According to this interpretation, it is from among an already created humanity that God "forms and appoints" one particular human family as his royal priests to oversee the Heaven-on-Earth place.
4. It means that once Cain is exiled east of Eden, he joins this wider Genesis 1 humanity as he marries, begins a family, and builds a city and flourishing civilization.
5. It means that God's creation of a cosmic mountain temple (Eden) and the creation of a royal priesthood is presented as a terrestrial creation story, similar to other ancient Near Eastern temple building accounts (The Ba'al Epic from Ugarit, 13th century B.C.; Enuma Elish, 18th and 13th centuries B.C.).

View 2 Resources

- Walton, John H. (2015). [*The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2-3 and the Human Origins Debate*](#). IVP Academic: An Imprint of InterVarsity Press.
- Stordalen, Terje (2000). [*Echoes of Eden: Genesis 2-3 and Symbolism of the Garden of Eden in Biblical Hebrew Literature*](#). Peeters Publishers.
- Postell, Seth D. (2011). [*Adam as Israel: Genesis 1-3 as the Introduction to the Torah and Tanakh*](#). Pickwick Publications.

Challenges with View 2

There are some challenges with this interpretation. Later iterations of the pattern in Genesis 1 and 2 are repeated while seemingly talking about the same thing. For example, in the Noah story, imagery is repeated from both Genesis 1 and 2.

Genesis 1 Patterns

- Genesis 9:1: God tells Noah to be fruitful and multiply and fill the land.
- Genesis 9:3: God gives the animals as food just as he gave the plants.
- Genesis 9:6: Image of God language is repeated as the reason to not shed the blood of another human.

Genesis 2 Patterns

- Genesis 9:20: Noah gets off the boat and plants a garden.
- Genesis 9:21: Noah eats the fruit of the vine and it doesn't go well.

In this passage, Noah is representing a Genesis 1 and 2 humanity at the same time. The idea of what it means to be a human is not separated into pre-Adam and Eve and post-Adam and Eve humans. Within this pattern, it would seem the biblical authors are saying the humanity of Genesis 1 is the same as Adam and Eve in the garden of Genesis 2.

Patterns in Genesis 1:26-28

In Genesis 1, we meet a figure, Adam, which is often translated as "man." In English, the word man is closely associated with being a male. However, the biblical authors would have understood "*adam*" to be a generic category like "human." The image of God poem found in Genesis 1:26-28 sheds light on what it means to be a human.

Day 6: God Delegates Earthly Rulers

26 And God said,
"Let us **make human**
in our image,
according to our likeness;
and let them **rule**
over the fish of the sea
and over the birds of the sky
and over the cattle
and over all the land
and over every creeper that creeps on the land ."

27 And God **created human** in his image,
in the image of God he created him ;
male and female he created them .

28 And God blessed them,
"Be fruitful and multiply,
and fill the land,
and subdue it;
and rule
over the fish of the sea
and over the birds of the sky
and over every living creature that creeps on the land."

Genesis 1-2:3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2020).

At the center of this literary unit (1:27) is a three line poem. Notice how each line has three key elements, inviting us to ponder the relationships between the concepts.

This poetic parallelism makes clear that the divine image is constituted in some crucial way by the duality of gender. Somehow God is imaged in a special way through the unity of humanity as one species that consists of a duality of distinct others. Humanity is one and more than one at the same time, and this offers an important image of God's divine identity. The following narrative of the Eden story then presents a dramatized narrative that expands on the concepts presented in this poem.

- The making of the one: Adam formed of the dust
- The one cannot fulfill his commission as only one: No helper is found suitable for Adam
- The one becomes two: Eve is formed from Adam
- The two become one again: Adam and Eve become one flesh

This portrait of humans as the divine and royal image of Yahweh is precisely the claim of [Psalm 8](#), which is the product of a sustained meditation on Genesis 1.

Genesis 1 (and the later reflection in [Psalm 8](#)) gives us the whole story of humanity in one opening movement. It functions as the ideal portrait of creation, and [Genesis 2:4](#) is the hinge that gets us into reality.

Reflection Question

Genesis 2:5 says, "Now no shrub of the field was yet on the earth, and no plant of the field had yet sprouted, for the Lord God had not sent rain upon the earth, and there was no man to cultivate the ground." How do these details compare to the account in Genesis 1?